

When Affirmation Replaces Transformation: The New Theology Of Mainline Churches

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Something profound has happened inside portions of American Christianity.

The church was once understood as a place where sinners came to encounter a Savior who loved them enough to change them. Increasingly, however, some mainline denominations appear to be embracing a very different message: come as you are--and expect the church to affirm you as you are.

That distinction may sound subtle. It is not.

It represents a fundamental change in what Christianity is supposed to accomplish.

One of the clearest examples can be seen in the direction of the Evangelical Lutheran Church in America and the people shaping its youth ministries.

The ELCA Youth Ministry Network is preparing for its January 2027 Extravaganza, a national gathering designed specifically for adults working with children, youth and families. The importance of such an event should not be underestimated. These are the people who return to local congregations to disciple teenagers, shape curriculum, lead retreats and influence the next generation of Lutherans.

And the conference lineup tells parents something important about the theological culture those leaders are being asked to absorb.

One general-session speaker, Rev. Emmy Kegler, is described by the conference itself as a "queer Christian" who lives with her wife and children. Featured musician Spencer LaJoye is advertised as making "queer indie folk music." Rev. Jen Collins, who has spent years in children, youth and family ministry, will serve as the gathering's General Session Theologian.

The significance of that position should not be missed: Collins is being entrusted with helping establish the theological framework through which youth workers understand ministry itself. When the people shaping that framework operate within a progressive approach that emphasizes personal identity, "belovedness," advocacy and contemporary sexual ethics, parents have every reason to ask what biblical boundaries remain--and who ultimately gets to define them.

The issue is not whether Christians should love people who identify as LGBT. Of course they should. Christianity commands believers to love everyone.

The question is whether Christian love still includes the courage to say that every part of every person's life--including sexuality, identity, desires and behavior--must be brought under the authority of Christ.

That is where the theological fault line now runs.

From Transformation To Affirmation

Historic Christianity makes a radical claim: every human being bears the image of God, every human being is loved by God, every human being is affected by sin, and every human being needs redemption.

No one arrives at the foot of the cross needing only affirmation.

We arrive needing transformation.

Jesus welcomed sinners, but He also called people to repentance. Paul described conversion as becoming a "new creation." Romans 12 commands believers not to conform to the world but to be transformed by the renewing of their minds.

Christianity was never simply: "God loves you exactly as you are, therefore remain exactly as you are."

Yet that is increasingly the practical message emerging from parts of progressive Christianity.

The order has been reversed.

Rather than allowing Scripture to judge our identities and desires, Scripture is increasingly being reinterpreted so that our identities and desires cannot be judged.

Instead of asking, "What does God require of me?" the question becomes, "How must the church change so that I never feel challenged by what God requires?"

That is not a minor adjustment in pastoral tone.

It is a different theology.

This Is Not One Conference

The upcoming Extravaganza is not an isolated event.

At the ELCA's 2018 Youth Gathering, an 11-year-old transgender child addressed thousands of Lutheran youth. The ELCA's own account celebrated the presentation and explicitly identified the child as transgender.

In 2024, the denomination's own Youth Gathering blog reported that teenagers attending the event received "sparkle blessings" from local drag queens in a recreated Garden of Eden setting.

Those details matter because they demonstrate continuity.

What was once regarded as a controversial cultural movement outside the church has increasingly been welcomed, celebrated and incorporated into the church's own youth culture.

And when that happens repeatedly, parents should stop treating each incident as a strange exception.

It is becoming part of the formation process.

Who Is Discipling The People Who Disciple Your Children?

Parents naturally focus on the local youth pastor.

But the larger question is: Who trained the youth pastor?

Who produced the curriculum?

Who selected the speakers at national gatherings?

Who determines what "inclusion," "justice," "belovedness" and "faithfulness" mean?

Who decides which identities should be affirmed and which biblical teachings should be reconsidered?

Youth ministry conferences matter precisely because they multiply influence.

A controversial presentation to 30,000 teenagers may last an evening.

Train hundreds or thousands of ministry leaders, however, and those ideas can influence churches for years.

They enter Bible studies.

They enter counseling conversations.

They enter confirmation classes.

They enter youth camps.

Eventually they become assumptions so deeply embedded that young Christians may never even realize they are being taught a modern reinterpretation of Christianity rather than the historic faith.

That is the real significance of what is happening.

The battle is not merely over whether a church will "welcome" LGBT people.

The battle is over who has authority to define sin, repentance, identity, marriage and holiness.

Parents Can No Longer Afford To Assume

This is bigger than the ELCA.

Every Christian parent should investigate what their denomination actually teaches.

Do not assume that because a church retains crosses, robes, hymns, communion and Christian vocabulary that it has retained historic Christian doctrine.

Ask what the denomination teaches about marriage.

Ask what it teaches about gender.

Ask what its seminaries teach.

Ask what children hear at national youth gatherings.

Ask who is training youth leaders.

Ask whether Scripture is treated as the authority over culture--or whether Scripture is continually being revised to accommodate culture.

Because once the second approach takes hold, there is almost no stopping point.

If personal identity determines how Scripture must be interpreted, why should sexual orientation be the final category?

Why should marriage remain limited to two people?

Why should any sexual boundary inherited from historic Christianity remain beyond reconsideration?

Once the principle changes from "our lives must conform to Scripture" to "Scripture must accommodate our lives," every remaining boundary eventually becomes negotiable.

That is why this debate matters far beyond sexuality.

It concerns the very purpose of Christianity.

Is Christianity a message telling us that God will affirm whatever identity we construct for ourselves?

Or is it the far more demanding--and far more hopeful--message that Christ loves us enough to remake us?

There is an enormous difference between saying:

"You are welcome here."

And saying:

"Nothing about you may ever be challenged here."

The first is Christian hospitality.

The second can become theological surrender.

A church can still sing hymns, preach sermons, distribute communion and speak constantly about Jesus while gradually redefining what following Jesus actually means.

And that should concern every parent.

Because when affirmation replaces transformation, Christianity eventually loses the very thing that makes the Gospel good news.

Christ did not come merely to confirm us.

He came to redeem us.

And redemption means change.

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